

18. Are you currently being “retrained” or are taking coaching sessions?

Again, a tricky one. Retraining or coaching is often a way to try and save an employee who has lost his or her way. It shows that the company or your boss still gives a crap. But it also has a darker side. It’s another one of those “cover the company’s butt” scenarios, in which HR demonstrates they did everything they possibly could to make things work. And alas, it didn’t, so they had to let you go. Not a major warning sign on its own, but combined with a few others, this has danger written all over it.

19. Has your immediate boss or mentor gone bye-bye?

If someone you trusted and respected, like a boss or mentor, is no longer around for whatever reason (promotion, fired, quit), this could spell trouble. This person may have been the only one keeping the wolf from your door. And there’s an easy way to find out. Is it now impossible to get projects approved? Are you being left out of meetings? Does nothing run smoothly now that this person is no longer on the scene? If this is the case, that’s cause for concern.

20. Have you recently been promoted to a position of less responsibility?

What a cunning ruse this one is. It’s quite simple but efficient. In your old position, it may have been very difficult or almost impossible to get rid of you. But if the company promotes you into a newly created role, with less responsibility and no direct reports, then you have a new scenario: position elimination. It’s hard to fire someone. It’s easy to eliminate a position. You can get rid of anyone, even protected classes (older folks, pregnant ladies, etc.) if you simply eliminate a position. So, be afraid. Be very afraid. If you were formerly “Account Manager” and are now “Director in Charge of Special Project Development,” you may as well clear out your desk right now. Remember, three or more of these, and you’re more than likely heading for the unemployment line. Take a long hard look at your working life, and do something about it. After all, if you’re not good enough for them, then they’re not good enough for you. — **Paul Michael**

